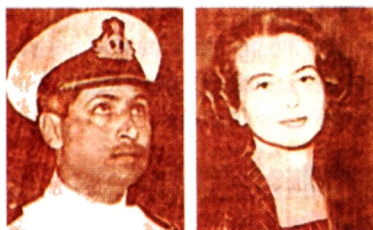


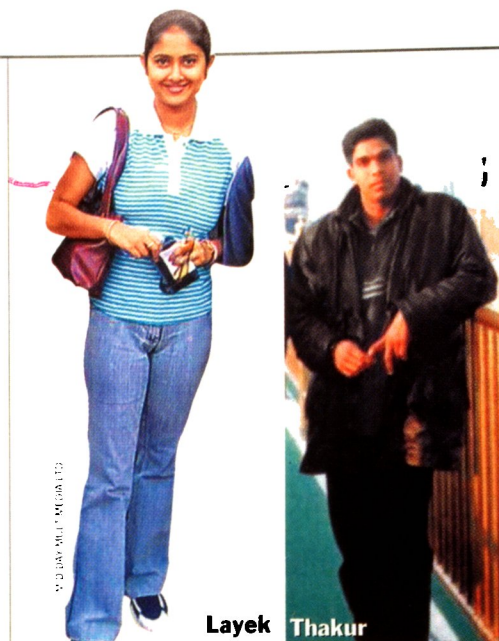
NANAVATI CASE

Almost 50 years ago, the murder trial of a naval officer for killing his wife's lover made big news. The year 1959 became a landmark for the Indian judiciary, thanks to the last jury trial of Kawas Manekshaw Nanavati, a commander with the Indian Navy, who was accused of killing his wife's lover. The incident fired the imagination of an entire nation which rallied to support the man who killed his friend for violating



Nanavati and Sylvia
his wife's honour.

Nanavati had settled down in Mumbai with his English-born wife Sylvia, their two sons and a daughter. Nanavati's frequent absence drove Sylvia into the arms of her husband's close friend Prem Bhagwandas Ahuja. When her lover refused to marry her, a crest-fallen Sylvia confessed to her husband, who drove to his friend's house, after dropping his family at a film theatre, and asked his friend if he would marry his wife. On being told that Ahuja possibly couldn't "marry all the women he slept with", Nanavati pumped bullets into his friend's body and confessed his crime.



Layek Thakur

KAUSHAMBI LAYEK MURDER

ACCUSED: Manish Thakur

CAUSE: GIRLFRIEND'S ALLEGED AFFAIR WITH A COLLEAGUE

PLACE: Mumbai

DATE: May 16, 2007

THE CASE: Naval officer Manish Thakur killed Kaushambi Layek with a chopper in Hotel Sun-N-Sheel and fled. Though married himself, he suspected his girlfriend of having an affair with another man.

marital sex while 25 per cent had, at some point, indulged in casual sex. Says filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt: "The American way of life is making inroads into a straitjacketed society like ours, which looks at women in a certain way. Today's young India is defined by lust, love and violence, which outpace everything else."

The territorial behaviour of men towards their women is neither restricted to any particular age group nor any economic strata. Any sign of independence or sexual adventurism by a woman today evokes a violent reaction from men. Sixteen-year-old Karishma Shah in Pune was attacked with a knife by her friend Hemant Misal for being friends with other boys. Often parents and neighbours are caught unawares by the intensity and violence coming from seemingly "normal" people.

India's changing attitude to extra-marital affairs is pretty much chronicled by the television and entertainment industry, as the real life continues to inspire the reel. From furtive midnight phone calls received by the husband in a Career Launcher advertisement to the soap operas on television, sexual philandering and one-night stands are par for the course. If Mandira was a vamp, who lured Mihir into an extra-marital relationship in the iconic *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* in 2001, today all such smokescreens have been shed. Tulsi and Parvati may continue to teach the tenets of upright, middle-class morality, but the new generation *bahus* and *betis* are no longer the virtuous *pativrata* wives. With multiple generation leaps, soaps are shedding the garb of morality the women have been shrouded in. Giving the sanctity of the *saat pheras* a miss, the 20-something characters—or the new generation as they are called—are exploring multiple relationships, finding love outside marriage and even having children out of wedlock.

Says Nivedita Basu, creative head at Balaji Telefilms: "Society is changing

"Today's young India is increasingly defined by lust, love and violence, which outpace everything else in life."

MAHESH BHATT, FILMMAKER

